

The Muslim rule in Bengal had its beginning in the opening years of the thirteenth century (1204 AD). Long before this, the Arab Muslims had contact with Bengal, which was primarily commercial and religious in nature and limited to the coastal regions, like Chittagong.

The process of Muslim expansion in Bengal began with the military adventures of Bakhtiyar khalji, who made a sudden attack on Bengal in 1204-05 AD and captured nadia, Nadia was the temporary capital of king Laksmansena. Now here we see that India or Delhi had been taken over by central Asians who were driven out of their land by Mongols. BK was part of that team. He then captured Gaur, which was the traditional capital of Bengal, made it his capital and spent there about two years.

He then introduced administrative system for his newly conquered territories.

He established a kind of clannish feudalism in his territory. He organized his conquered area into units and placed them in charge of his trusted generals. Ruling system was military feudalism with chieftains loyal to, BK and he was loyal to Delhi.

Besides arranging his administrative system, Bakhtiyar also found time to lay the foundation of Muslim society in Bengal by establishing central Asian institutions like mosques for worshipers, madrasas for the schooling of Muslim children, and Khanqahs for the Sufis to preach the religion.

Bakhtiyar then went to his Tibet conquest but it was a total disaster and he, a broken man, either died of fever or was put to death by Ali Mardan Khalji only three months after his return to Devkot.

On the basis of the contemporary and modern sources a fair idea of the geographical extent of Bakhtiyar's territory may be determined. In Bengal it included the districts of Rajmahal, Malda, Dinajpur, Rajshahi, Rangpur and Bogra in the north.

After this we see many wars of succession and infighting, killing as no dynastic rule existed but of mercenaries means hired soldiers. There was expansion of territories through conquests of the region including Vanga, Bihar, Samatata etc. I have mentioned before that Bengal rulers always had an uneasy relationship with Delhi. Sometimes we see the revolts from Bengal rulers sometimes conflicts and invasion or interventions by Delhi forces.

The dynasty founded by Ilyas Shah, ruled Bengal for nearly one hundred and fifty years (1342-1487 AD) although there was an interruption of about twenty-three years. The period of Ilyas Shahi rule is important and significant. The Independent Sultanate, initiated by Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah, was united and saw widespread

expansion. The Muslim administration was given a distinct shape in this period. Arts and literature, particularly Bangla literature, flourished. The Muslim rulers were appreciative to the local people and opened the door for their participation in the administration of the country. So The process of transformation of an alien Muslim rule into Bengali Muslim rule was started during this period. Above all, the whole territory, which was before known not by any single name but by its different regional names such as Vabga, Gauda etc, came to be designated as Bangalah.

Haji Iliyas, the founder of the dynasty and the real founder of the Independent Sultanate of Bengal, rose at satgaon to the position of Malik and, later became the master of Satgaon. Then Haji Iliyas, took the throne of Lakhnauti with the title of Sultan Shamsuddin Abul Muzaffar Iliyas Shah in 1342 AD and laid the foundation of the Iliyas Shahi Sultanate in Bengal, which lasted for nearly one hundred and fifty years (1342-1487 AD). By 1352 A D Iliyas succeeded in defeating ikhtiyaruddin ghazi shah, ruler of Sonargaon, and brought the whole of Bengal under his authority. **Iliyas Shah was a strong and efficient ruler and by his understanding and political judgement earned for himself the titles of Shah-i-Bangalah, Shah-i-Bangaliyan and Sultan-i-Bangalah. He died at pandua in 1358 AD after a reign of about sixteen years.**

Sikandar Shah, Iliyas' son and successor, enjoyed a long and prosperous reign of about 33 years and died sometime around 1390 in the course of a fight with his son Azam Shah at Goalpara near Pandua. On his death, Azam Shah took the throne with the title of Sultan ghiyasuddin azam shah. He was a capable ruler with a profound regard for the law. But his son ruled Bengal for a short period of one year and a few months. During his reign raja Ganesha, a Hindu zamindar of the Rajshahi District, became powerful and took the throne of Bengal. the rule of the Iliyas Shahi dynasty was interrupted.

the Iliyas Shashi dynasty was restored when the nobles placed Nasiruddin, a descendant of Sultan Shamsuddin Iliyas Shah, on the throne of Bengal in 1435-36 AD. Assuming the title of Nasiruddin Mahmud shah, the new sultan reigned peacefully for about twenty-four years. He was succeeded by his son RUKNUDDIN BARBAK SHAH, who was just, liberal, learned and a wise sultan. RUKNUDDIN BARBAK SHAH appreciated Abyssinian slaves and recruited them in large numbers. The Habshi slaves, consequently, became a powerful factor in Bengal politics. **Barbak Shah died and was succeeded by his son SHAMSUDDIN YUSUF SHAH. The distinctive feature of later iliyas shahi rule was that it strictly and fairly applied the Sharia laws in state affairs and charged the Ulama to see that the laws of Islam were followed in all parts of life.**

At the end of Ilyas Shahi rule the Abyssinian slaves became very powerful in the court of Bengal and occupied most of the important positions. Last ruler of Ilyas Shahi was murdered by one of his slaves, and the rule of the Ilyas Shahi dynasty came to an end.

The Elias shahi period saw a remarkable expansion of the territory of the Bengal Sultanate under Practically the whole of Bengal and some other territories in the west and north-east came under the Bengal Sultanate. The Ilyas Shahi dynasty, with remarkable stability, produced able rulers who were noted for their tolerance and enlightenment. To have ruled over a people of an alien faith for nearly seventy years was in itself a great achievement; to be reestablished was an even greater one. It was a singular proof of their popularity.

At the end of Ilyas Shahi rule, the Abyssinian (Ethiopian) slaves became a dangerously powerful element in the court of Bengal. Shahzada, a Habshi leader of the Abyssinian slaves seized the throne by murdering the last ruler of the house of Ilyas Shah in 1487 AD.

The rule of the Habshis (Abyssinians) in Bengal lasted nearly six years. They were oppressive rulers and they were isolated from the people. So Alauddin Husain Shah took the throne by assassinating the Habshi Sultan under whom he had served as wazir. He was elected sultan by the leading nobles in 1494 AD and established Hussain Shahi rule. **His rule saw the territorial expansion of the Sultanate of Bengal. He conquered Kamarupa and Kamta and also his troops conquered Assam. He attained some brief success in his conflicts against the king of Orissa and inscribed the legend 'conqueror of Kamrup and Kamta, and Jajnagar and Orissa' on his coins. He succeeded in seizing a part of Tippera to his kingdom.**

Chittagong formed an important part of his kingdom. Towards the end of Husain Shah's reign, a Portuguese mission came to Bengal to establish diplomatic links. The country enjoyed undisturbed peace and Vijaya Gupta, the contemporary poet mentioned him as *nrpati-tilaka* (the tilak-mark of kings), *jagatabhusana* (the adornment of the universe) and *Krsna-avatara* (the incarnation of Krsna).

His policy towards the Hindus was marked by tolerance and liberalism; some of the most important offices were held by Hindus. His Muslim governors patronised

Kavindra Parameshvara and Shrikara Nandi, who prepared the Bangla version of the MAHABHARATA.

Husain Shah offered all facilities to Sri Chaitanya in spreading of vaishava religion. The jiziyah tax was not imposed in Husain Shahi Bengal. Husain Shah and his successors tried to strengthen the foundation of the state on the basis of the support and sympathy of the people of different religion and creed. The reign of Husain Shah establishes a brilliant era in the history of medieval Bengal.

Alauddin Husain Shah was succeeded in 1519 AD by his eldest son Nusrat, who took the title of Sultan Nusrat Shah. Taking advantage of the significant political changes that were taking place in northern India Nusrat expanded his territory into Tirhut which is northern Bihar. Though he gave shelter to a few defeated Afghans, he cleverly tried to avoid any confrontation with Babur, who had appeared in the eastern Indian scene after his victory at Panipath (1526). Nusrat declared neutrality and avoided having any connection with the anti-Mughal confederacy that was formed by Mahmud Lodi with Afghan chiefs. But in spite of these plottings, Nusrat could not avoid a direct conflict with Babur.

Nusrat faced difficulties in the battle of the Ghogra, so he concluded it through peace with Babur and saved Bengal from future attacks or invasions. Nusrat avoided joining the Afghans in the battle of Daurah (1531) in which Humayun defeated the Afghans headed by Mahmud Lodi. Bengal's power on Kamrupa and Kamta remained till the end of Nusrat's rule. Towards the end of 1521 two Portuguese missions came to the court of Nusrat to establish diplomatic relations with Bengal. The Portuguese were active during his rule in the Bay of Bengal. His governors in Chittagong had to deal with the Portuguese 'hazard' in the coastal area off Chittagong several times. While visiting his father's tomb at Gaur, one of his slaves is said to have killed him. After this we see the decline of the Husain Shahi rule. The successors of Nusrat Shah were not as efficient or strong rulers as their ancestors. The governors of distant regions of Bengal became practically independent.

Afghan Rule started in Bengal in 1539 after the defeat of Humayun at Chausa at the hands of Sher Khan and ended in 1576 with the Mughal victory at Rajmahal over Daud Karrani. But long before Sher Khan had seized Bengal the Afghans had entered the services of the Bengal sultans. The sultans of Bengal used to recruit Afghans in their services. So by the time Sher Shah conquered Bengal, the Afghans were no strangers. They now found their own man on the throne, first of Bengal and Bihar and ultimately of the Indian empire. Realising the importance of Bengal for his empire building, Sher Shah paid his highest attention for its proper administrative reorganisation. He subdivided Bengal including Chittagong into a number of smaller units, each under a separate governor. Sher Shah's

plan worked well and the Afghans became so permanent in Bengal that its climate and culture had changed them almost beyond recognition with the non-Afghan Bengalis.

Islam Shah, the son and successor of Sher Shah, established a very firm control over the whole of Bengal. But in his further centralised the administration he appointed as governor his own relative Muhammad Khan Sur in 1545 AD. Bengal governor Muhammad Sur declared independence in 1553 AD. His successors ruled Bengal up to 1563 AD, when his rule was brought to an end with the rule of the Karrani Afghans in Bengal.

In the 16th century we see the rise and fall of a new Afghan dynasty in eastern India. During the rule of Sulaiman karrani we see The conquest of Orissa in 1567 AD. Sulaiman later captured Kuch Bihar in 1568 AD as well

Practicality and far-sightedness maintained Sulaiman's relation with the Mughals. He displayed unique statesmanship and skillful diplomacy by following the wise policy of keeping a good relationship with the Mughals with occasional gifts and presents as well as by promising to recite the khutba and make coins in the name of Akbar. Sulaiman Shah Karrani died and. His son Daud Khan Karrani took the power.Daud introduced absolute authority by having the khutba read and coins made in his own name which made Akbar angry. There was a war between The Mughals and daud. That battle ended through signing of the Peace Treaty of Katak whereby Daud is said to have agreed to be loyal towards Mughal empire and committing himself never to revolt. But again The battle of rajmahal, fought in 1576 AD, sealed Daud's fate. He was captured alive and later he was executed. His defeat ended afgan rule.

Mughal rule was established in Bengal after the defeat of the Karrani Afghan Sultan, Daud Khan in the battle of Rajmahal, 12 July 1576 at the hands of Khan Jahan. After that the Mughals became determined and made sustained efforts to establish their authority over Bengal, till ultimately in 1612, Islam Khan, brought the whole of Bengal (except Chittagong) under the Mughal control.

With Daud Khan's defeat ended the Sultanate rule in Bengal, but this in no way meant the end of Bengali resistance to the Delhi imperial power. Different military chieftains and bhuiyans, some of whom were powerful enough to be rajas (kings), controlled different pockets of Bengal. They tried to resist the Mughal aggression as independent or semi-independent chieftains. Among those who resisted the Mughals, some bhuiyans, known as bara-bhuiyans or twelve territorial landholders stand out the most prominent.

The rajas, bhuiyans and the zamindars who put up stubborn resistance to the Mughals were many, they were about 36 in number. The bara-bhuiyans resisted the Mughal aggression for several decades. The chief of the bara-bhuiyans was Isa Khan. He combined with other bhuiyans and led them in the struggle against the Mughals till his death. Isa Khan's son Musa Khan took the leadership of the bara-bhuiyans and put up a stubborn resistance to the Mughals. But they were at last forced to submit to the imperial armies led by Subahdar Islam Khan in the rule of Emperor Jahangir.

Islam Khan later took up the task of subjugating the rest of the resisting elements. For political reason, he transferred the capital from Rajmahal to Dhaka. The bara-bhuiyans were then finally defeated. As a political strategy, the defeated bhuiyans and chiefs were not allowed to keep their territories under their control. Instead, they were motivated to work under the Mughals.

Anyways, Shaista Khan was appointed the subahdar of Bengal after Mir Jumla. He was not only of noble birth, but also an accomplished Persian poet and scholar and a great general. He served in various parts of the empire before taking the duty as subadar in Bengal. Shaista Khan ruled Bengal for twenty-two years. Though his age was past 60, he ruled Bengal with strength. He was accompanied by a few grown up and gifted sons who helped him in administering the country. They held charge of different sarkars or divisions, the father and the children sharing the administration and they ruled the country with capability.

Shaista Khan's greatest achievement in Bengal was his conquest of Chittagong. The Magh king of Arakan with the help of Portuguese pirates attacked the Mughal province of Bengal whenever he found an opportunity. Moreover, the Portuguese pirates used to attack the coastal regions, looted property and enslaved men, women and children. The Portuguese piracy was a regular threat. So Shaista Khan's policy was to make the area safe by conquering Chittagong from the king of Arakan and also to save the coastal area from the danger of the pirates and making it a part of the empire. Soon he conquered Chittagong and made the whole region free from the Arakanese invasions.

Aurangzeb appointed Azim-us-Shan his grandson as the subadar of Bengal. Azim-us-Shan used his time in Bengal in gathering money, by whatever means he

could, because he was sure about a war of succession after the death of Aurangzeb. In exchange of cash gift, he first permitted the English East India Company to purchase the three villages of Sutanuti, Govindpur and Kalikata in 1698 and paving the way to the ultimate establishment of British rule in India within half a century.

One very important event of Azim-us-Shan's subadari was his disagreement with the diwan, Murshid Quli Khan. Diwan means financial minister. To avoid his presence, Murshid Quli Khan shifted his capital to Murshidabad. So Dhaka lost the glory of being the capital of Mughal Bengal. It is stated by many scholars that the prosperity of Dhaka and its surrounding area in Eastern Bengal began to decline since the transfer of the government institutions to Murshidabad and Patna.

Murshid Quli Khan, was blessed by the support of Aurangzeb, he became the practical ruler of Bengal subah. He was appointed subahdar of Orissa, diwan of three provinces, Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. He made the Bengal economy dynamic and paid imperial taxes regularly. During his subah, Bengal flourished economically. The foreigners who came to participate in the Bengal export trade were forced to observe the laws of Bengal. Murshid Quli Khan, though he paid tributes or money to the Delhi rulers regularly, became practically an independent nawab. So at the time of his death, he nominated his grandson, Sarfaraz Khan, to succeed him. But soon he was overthrown by his father, Shuja Uddin Khan, who became the Nawab of Bengal. Shujauddin Khan, at the time of his death, nominated his son Sharfaraz Khan to the masnad in 1739. But Sarfaraz was a weak ruler and Alivardi Khan overthrew him in 1740. Alivardi Khan's rule was marked by annual Maratha raids. He had to buy peace with the Marathas, by practically surrendering Orissa and paying 12 lakhs of rupees to the Marathas annually. Alivardi was a kind man and skillful ruler. The rise of the banking family, the Jagat Sheth, was a remarkable feature of his regime. It was the Sheths who were mainly responsible for the political change that occurred through the staged battle of Palashi in 1757. Alivardi Khan died at the age of 80. Earlier he nominated Sirajuddaula, his grandson from his daughter's side, to the throne.

Sirajuddaula, the new nawab was only 23 when he took the throne of Bengal. Soon he found himself surrounded by enemies both local and foreign. In his own house his greatest enemy was Ghaseti Begum the eldest sister of his mother. Shawkat Jang, his cousin, living in Purnia, was another great rival. Then there was Mir Jafar Ali Khan who was the commander-in-chief of Alivardi's army. Most dangerous was the Jagat Sheth family which controlled the Bengal money market and who had many sympathizers in the Durbar. The greatest enemy was the English East India Company, which was quite openly ignoring the nawab. Without taking any permission from the nawab they were fortifying Fort William of Calcutta and taking other military preparations. Fort William was made a safe haven for criminals and violators of the law of the land.

To bring the English under law, Nawab Sirajuddaula attacked Calcutta. Colonel Robert Clive entered into a conspiracy with the disaffected officials of the nawab, Mir Jafar, Jagat Sheth, Raiballabh and others. The Fort William Council agreed to a secret treaty with Mir Jafar promising to place him on the throne, and Mir Jafar agreeing to grant territorial, financial and trade facilities to the English. Armed with this treaty and the treachery of Mir Jafar and others, Clive arrived at Palashi and took position on 23 June 1757. Siraj also came to the place to encounter the company's army. But to his shock he found that the larger part of his own army defied his command and stood silent. Siraj fled from the field, but was captured and brought back to the capital and killed. Clive, in accordance with the terms of the secret deal, placed Mir Jafar on the throne. The Mughal power was practically over with the event of Palashi though the English took a decade more to assert real power.

Mughal revenue administration in Bengal was elaborately designed. It was made separate from the general administration. the administration was called nizamat while the revenue administration was called the diwani. While the general administration including defense and warfare and maintenance of peace was in the hands of Nazim or subahdar, the revenue administration was under the diwan. The diwan was lower than the subahdar in rank, but he was completely independent in financial and revenue matters. The rule for separation of powers and duties was made to protect imperial interests and those of the raiyats, zamindars, taluqdars, ie those who were connected with land.

In the Mughal system, lands were also divided into Khalsa and jagir. Khalsa lands were directly administered by the state through the diwan and his staff. Jagir lands were those which were given to the officers, civil or military, for their services, i.e. they were paid by jagirs. Lands were also gifted for maintenance of religious institutions and were granted to religious persons like saints, sufis etc. An important feature of the revenue administration was the existence of zamindars, who acted as middlemen between the rayats and the government.

With the coming of the Mughals Bengal saw the working of certain new forces in her social, economic and cultural life. These forces changed Bengal's life and thought and as one scholar said, 'the outer world came to Bengal and Bengal went out of herself to the outer world.' Unlike the previous period, when she enjoyed independence, free from outside control, Bengal now became a part, a province of the centralised Mughal government, under one administration, one law, one official

language, a uniform official cadre and uniform currency. Muslims from various countries came to Bengal from the beginning, but with the introduction of Mughal rule and with the prospect of peace, prospect of employment opportunities also increased. So scholarly Muslims, i.e. those who pursued peaceful life, like the ulama, teachers, poets, physicians and merchants came to Bengal in larger number. There also came the Shia ulama and scholars in the train of Shia political leaders, subahdars, diwans and others.

Some very prominent Mughal subahdars were Shias. Murshid Quli Khan had practically established a Shia dynasty which ready to welcome the talented and religious Shias. Names of many Persian poets are found who either made Bengal their permanent home or passed a part of their career in Bengal under the patronage of the subahdars and other high officers. Persian became the official language and not only Persian literature was produced in the country but also Persian language influenced local Bengali language. Bengali poets borrowed Persian themes and Persian words in large number have entered into the local language. State revenue service was more elaborate than before and so the zamindars, muqaddams, patwaris, i.e. all those locals connected with the revenue service had to learn Persian language in which the accounts were maintained. Unlike the Bengal sultans, Mughal subahdars came to Bengal for particular terms. So they had neither the capacity nor the time to learn local language, and hence the agents of local zamindars stationed at the court had to be masters of Persian language.

During early Mughal rule, higher posts in the revenue department were reserved for Muslims and Hindus coming from upper India but later, particularly from the time of Murshid Quli Khan, these high posts passed into the hands of the Hindus. For example we see in the time of Sirajuddaula, nanda kumar and Omi Chand etc. were prominent Hindu officers. With the growth of trade and commerce came the Marwari Banking families like the family of Jagat Sheth; some zamindars, for example the zamindar of Burdwan also came from upper India. In trade and commerce also Bengal's isolation was broken, she now took greater part in inter-provincial trade, the inland trade carried Bengal goods to Patna, Agra, Delhi and to Multan, while the sea-borne trade carried the goods to Madras and other areas.

In trade and commerce, Bengal came to limelight in history by her international trade. During the early Muslim-period, Bengal's products could be sold for money to a small extent. The foreign merchants buying the goods were Chinese, Malayese,

Arabs and Persians. Among the European traders, the Portuguese came first and opened trade in the first quarter of the 16th century. They first appeared at Chittagong, and later got permission to trade with Bengal. But they prospered when, with the permission from the Mughal emperor Akbar, they established a settlement at Hugli in 1580. The Portuguese established their supremacy in the sea, and got enormous profits out of their trade with Bengal. But soon the Portuguese collapsed, by the 17th century their power and trade began to decline. Their piratical activities and religious converting activities brought punishment from the Mughal rulers, but the main cause of their decline was the competition with other European companies.

The Dutch East India Company started their trade with Bengal in the beginning of the 17th century, the English East India Company followed them. Both the companies prospered in their trade with the privileges received from the Mughal government. They established their factories near Hugli. Later the English moved to Calcutta, and when the French company came, they established their factory at Chandernagar. and with the permission of subahdar Azimuddin, the English bought the three villages of Sutanuti, Govindpur and Kolkata and laid the foundation of the city of Calcutta. The goods that were exported from Bengal were fine cotton goods, coarse cotton textiles, silk and silk-textiles, rice etc.

So during the Mughal rule, we see enormous growth in Bengal's overseas trade. As against exports, the import of foreign companies was small, because except in some rare cases, the imported goods of the foreign companies could not attract the local consumers. The foreign companies, therefore brought in huge quantity of bullion Bullion is gold, silver, or other precious metals in the form of bars, foreign traders were giving capitals in the hands of Bengali producers and manufactures, and this had far-reaching effects in the country's economy. First, the money circulation rose to a great degree. Bengal could purchase goods from other countries and other provinces of India which was unimaginable before. Money prices and money wages also rose sharply in Bengal. This did not mean the increase in the real income, but upper class people certainly grew richer and possessed more items of luxury and government officials and revenue collecting middlemen made fortune.

And what is more important, as a result of greater export of local goods, there was great rise in the production of industrial and manufactured goods. A vast market was now opened for Bengal's cotton goods, silk and silk yarn, rice, sugar etc. The

agents of foreign companies as well as the individual buyers stood ready with a hung amount of cash in hand for almost any quantity that Bengal producers and manufacturers could offer. The foreign exporters also helped organising industrial production in the country in an efficient manner and in larger amounts They placed their agents at every market, approached workmen, and artisans; set up workshops at their factories where local labourers could work under European expert supervision.

The Mughals had been in peaceful possession of Bengal after its conquest had been complete. The piratical activities of the Portuguese in involvement with the Maghs of Arakan were also stopped after Shaista Khan's conquest of Chittagong in 1666. Before the Mughals, however, Bengal was notoriously famous as a rebel province. The then rulers of Delhi tried to solve the problem by decentralizing the administration but instead of following that policy, the Mughals appointed the emperor's sons and relatives and other very high and trusted civil servants.

Mughal rule in Bengal opened an era of peace and prosperity. The overseas trade, the entry of gold and silver turned Bengal actually a prosperous province. The foreign travellers from Portugal, Italy, France, England and Holland started coming to Bengal from the time she became open to European ships. All of them spoke very highly of Bengal's wealth, rich products and highly prized manufactured goods. The rich energy of the country, together with the beauty and good-nature of the local women, has given rise to a proverb in common use among the Portuguese, English and Dutch, that the Kingdom of Bengal has a hundred gates open for entrance, but not one for departure.